

How Family and Friends Can Help

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, spouses/partners, adult children, caregivers, friends

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

How Family and Friends Can Help

Why family and friends matter

Hearing loss affects conversations, routines, relationships, and shared activities. Family and friends can make a major difference. Small communication changes can reduce frustration and help the person with hearing loss stay included in everyday conversations.

Hearing loss is not selective listening

A person may hear well in one situation and poorly in another because listening depends on noise, distance, lighting, room acoustics, speaker voice, visual cues, and fatigue.

I can hear you, but I cannot understand you

Many adults with hearing loss can hear that someone is talking but cannot clearly understand the words. Shouting usually does not solve the problem and may distort speech. Clear speech, facing the listener, reduced noise, and rephrasing are often more helpful.

What not to do

- Do not speak from another room
- Do not turn away while talking
- Do not shout
- Do not repeat the same unclear word over and over
- Do not say "never mind"
- Do not assume hearing aids fix every situation

What helps most

- Get attention first
- Face the listener
- Speak clearly
- Move closer

- Reduce background noise
- Rephrase when needed
- Speak one at a time
- Write down important details
- Be patient and respectful

Involve family in hearing care when appropriate

Some adults benefit from bringing a communication partner to audiology appointments. The person with hearing loss should decide who they want involved.

Key Takeaway

Communication improves when family and friends face the listener, speak clearly, reduce background noise, rephrase rather than saying "never mind," and support hearing technology without criticism.

References

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